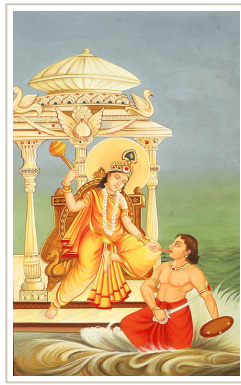


T A N T R A Y A

Supplementary Workbook · The Ten Mahavidyas

Bagalamukhi

She Who Seizes the Tongue



Bagalamukhi, golden and crowned, seizing the tongue of the demon of speech

Eighth of the Mahavidyas · The Stopping

Sovereign over momentum, mistress of stambhana

Mastery over the movement of energy, from impulse to continuation

Tantraya · Sacred Valley of Peru

At a Glance

RANK	Eighth of the ten Mahavidyas
NAME MEANS	“She of the crane face,” bagala being a corruption of vagla or baka, associated with stillness and single-pointed focus
FORM	Golden or yellow-complexioned, seated on a jewelled throne, one hand pulling a demon’s tongue, the other raised with a mace or club
VEHICLE / EMBLEMS	A club or mace, and the seized tongue of an adversary, often shown mid-strike
KARMA / ACTION	Stambhana, immobilizing: arresting motion at the exact point before it becomes irreversible
FOCUS OF THESE PRACTICES	Locating and mastering the interval between impulse and continuation, where freedom actually becomes possible

The Myth

The most widely told origin places Bagalamukhi’s appearance at a moment of planetary crisis. A demon named Madan performed severe austerities and was granted, by his own request, an unusual boon: whatever he spoke would immediately come true, and any weapon used against him would turn to water. He used this power to spread chaos through speech alone, and a great storm arose that threatened to destroy the created order entirely. The gods, unable to counter a threat that worked through the tongue rather than through force, appealed to the Divine Mother. She rose from a yellow lake, Haridra Sarovara, in the form of Bagalamukhi, seized the demon’s tongue directly with her hand, and in that single act his speech stopped, his power stopped, and the storm stopped with it.

What is distinct about this myth, compared to the origin stories of most of the other Mahavidyas, is where the intervention lands. She does not kill Madan. She does not destroy his body or his life. She stops one specific thing: the automatic, unstoppable continuation of his speech into effect. This is the entire key to her nature. Bagalamukhi’s

power is not annihilation. It is the arrest of momentum at the precise point where it would otherwise run on unchecked.

Symbolism and Image

Every element of her traditional image points toward stillness held inside enormous power, rather than the absence of power. She is seated, not standing or dancing like several of the other Mahavidyas; her throne itself, sometimes shown resting on a golden platform above the churning ocean, signals a stability that does not depend on being anywhere else. Her complexion and her ornaments are yellow or gold, the color tantra associates with stambhana and with the earth element, the element of stability and holding form.

The single most important detail is the hand pulling the tongue. In the body's own symbolism, the tongue is the organ through which the inner movement of thought becomes outer, irreversible action: a thought can be revised in silence, but a sentence spoken cannot be unspoken. Bagalamukhi's hand at the tongue represents the exact moment tantra is most interested in: the hinge between something that is still only internal and something that has become external and therefore consequential. Her other hand, raised with a mace, is not there to punish. It represents the same faculty in its more assertive form, the capacity to bring a movement to a full and immediate stop.

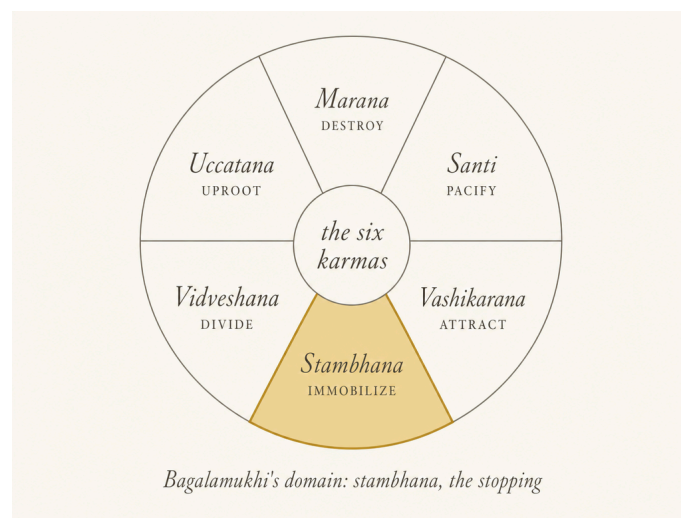
It is worth being precise about what this is not. She is not the goddess of suppression, of pushing feeling underground, of a forced or anxious self-control. Repression and stambhana are frequently confused, and the confusion causes real harm in people's practice. Repression pushes something down and out of awareness, where it continues to run unconsciously and often more destructively. Stambhana interrupts a process while remaining in full, vivid contact with it. The difference between the two is the difference between flinching away from an impulse and standing directly inside it while declining to let it complete itself. Bagalamukhi's entire teaching depends on keeping that distinction alive.

Understanding the Energy

Within the six classical actions a tantric practitioner can direct, pacifying, attracting, immobilizing, dividing, uprooting, and destroying, Bagalamukhi governs stambhana directly and is its clearest embodiment among the ten Mahavidyas. Where Dhumavati's uccatana removes something from where it has taken root, Bagalamukhi's stambhana

works earlier and faster: it arrests a process while it is still in motion, before it has had the chance to root at all.

Nearly every form of ordinary suffering shares one underlying structure. Something begins, and then continues automatically, without further consent. A thought becomes rumination. A desire becomes craving. A feeling becomes identification. An irritation becomes anger. An opinion becomes an argument. A habit becomes a life. Bagalamukhi's domain is the narrow, decisive interval between the beginning of a movement and its automatic continuation. She is the power that says, plainly, it stops here, not through suppression but because awareness has, in that moment, become stronger than momentum.



Bagalamukhi's domain: stambhana, the stopping

This is why her practices, correctly done, never feel like restraint for its own sake. What they train is closer to what could be called executive consciousness: the capacity to interrupt any automatic process, whether it is a thought, a reaction, a sentence, a fear, or a compulsion, long enough for an actual choice to enter where before there was only momentum. That interval, small as it is, is the exact location where freedom has always lived.

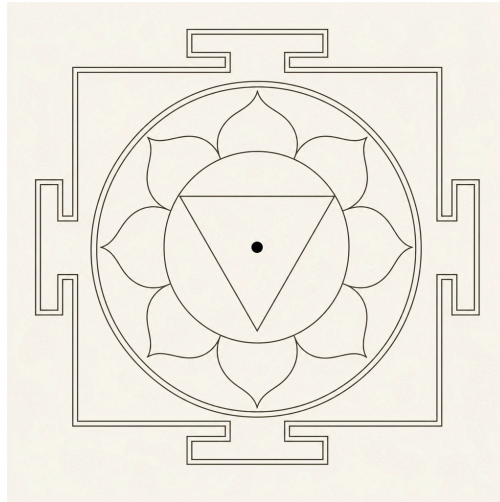
How to Work With These Practices

Bagalamukhi's practices are unusually precise for this material. They do not ask you to feel differently, believe differently, or understand anything new. They ask you to notice one exact thing, repeatedly and specifically: the moment something has already begun moving before you were aware of it, and the narrow gap that opens, however briefly, once you are.

None of what follows should be treated as suppression. If a practice starts to feel like white-knuckled restraint, forced silence, or performance for anyone watching, that is a sign to soften back into simple observation rather than push harder. The aim throughout is awareness outpacing momentum, not willpower fighting it.

Move through these in order. Each one isolates a different domain where momentum runs unexamined: thought, breath, speech, emotion, desire, attention, and finally the choosing faculty itself.

Practices



The Bagalamukhi Yantra: eight lotus petals within the bhupura, holding the single triangle of arrest

Bagalamukhi is not built around a technique that produces a state. She is built around a single recurring act of noticing: catching a process already underway and finding, inside it, the sliver of space where it was still possible to choose.

Everything below develops that one capacity from a different angle each time. By the seventh, they converge on a single, direct question: who is actually choosing here, and what happens the moment that question is asked in earnest.

Practice One – Discovering Momentum

Practice. Change nothing today. Simply observe momentum as it operates in you. Repeatedly through the day, ask: what has already begun moving before I became aware of it? Watch this in thoughts, emotional reactions, reaching for your phone, finishing other people's sentences, habitual routes you walk or drive without deciding to, eating, complaining. The aim is not to stop any of it. The aim is only to see it clearly, as it is actually happening.

Evening reflection. Where was I already on autopilot before awareness arrived, and how long had it been running before I noticed?

Practice Two – The Sacred Pause

Practice. Introduce exactly one conscious breath before every transition today: before standing, before speaking, before opening a door, before sending a message, before eating, before answering. Nothing else. Do not extend the pause, analyze it, or add any other technique to it. One breath, then proceed.

Evening reflection. In which of today's transitions did that single breath change what happened next, even slightly?

Practice Three – Speech

Practice. Reduce your speech by roughly a third today, not by force or artificial silence, but by simply not speaking what is unnecessary: explanations, justifications, stories, interruptions, gossip, repeating yourself. Before speaking, ask: does silence already contain what I am about to say? If it does, do not speak.

Evening reflection. How much of what I said today was actually necessary, and how much was momentum finding a way out through my mouth?

Practice Four – Reaction

Practice. Whenever something irritating happens today, do absolutely nothing for a full thirty seconds. No suppression, no analysis, no expression. Simply feel what is there, without acting on it or explaining it to yourself. Notice how much of the anger or irritation is pure momentum, and how much of it changes or disappears on its own within those thirty seconds.

Evening reflection. How much of today's reaction was momentum rather than something that actually needed to be expressed?

Practice Five – Desire

Practice. This may be the deepest practice here. Take every desire today, no matter how small, coffee, checking messages, scratching an itch, buying something, eating, speaking, and simply observe it. Wait one full minute before acting on it. This is not repression; it is investigation. Notice that desire moves, peaks, changes, and sometimes disappears entirely on its own before the minute is even up.

Evening reflection. Which desire today changed shape or vanished simply because I waited one minute before obeying it?

Practice Six – Attention

Practice. Several times today, stop completely for three minutes. Eyes open, nothing to achieve, nowhere to get to. Simply notice what continues moving inside you when your body has stopped moving: usually thoughts, planning, imagining, remembering. Let yourself discover that stillness of the body is not the same as stillness of mind, and that real stillness, when it arrives, is not passive but extraordinarily alive.

Evening reflection. What kept moving in me even after my body came to a complete stop?

Practice Seven – Sovereignty

Practice. Throughout today, ask experientially, not philosophically: who chooses? At each significant moment, ask directly: did I choose, or did habit? Did I choose, or did fear? Did I choose, or did conditioning? Let the honest answer arrive each time, even when it is uncomfortable. The insight this practice moves toward is simple and exact: freedom begins exactly where momentum ends.

Evening reflection. Having asked ‘who chooses’ all day, what did I discover about how much of my life actually runs on choice, and how much runs on momentum wearing choice’s face?

Advanced Exercises

The Last Word. Allow another person to have it. Notice the urge to reclaim it, to add one more sentence, to have the final say. Do nothing. Simply observe the energy of that urge as it rises and passes.

The Phone Practice. Whenever you reach for your phone, pause and ask why now: loneliness, habit, curiosity, avoidance, need? Then choose consciously whether to pick it up at all.

Interrupting Internal Speech. Whenever you notice repetitive thinking running on its own, instead of following the thought, become interested in the silence just before the next thought arrives. That gap is Bagalamukhi.

The Slow Day. Choose one day and move everything, walking, eating, speaking, driving, typing, at roughly eighty percent of your usual speed. Notice what becomes visible only once momentum has been deliberately lowered.

The Hidden Curriculum

Students working through this material typically begin by believing Bagalamukhi teaches restraint. By the end of these practices they usually discover she teaches something closer to sovereignty. Every unconscious movement, examined closely enough, turns out to be asking the same underlying question: who is actually in charge here? The answer, when it finally arrives honestly, is almost always surprising, and rarely flattering to whatever part of us assumed it already knew.

The Deeper Principle

Bagalamukhi's practices should gradually reveal one genuinely startling insight. Every spiritual tradition speaks, in one language or another, about freedom. Bagalamukhi asks a far more exact, almost scientific question: at precisely what point does freedom actually become possible? Not after enlightenment. Not after years of meditation. Not inside some elevated mystical state reserved for the advanced. In the infinitesimal interval between impulse and continuation. That interval, and nowhere else, is where consciousness enters and where a life stops being run entirely by what has already begun moving.

Her Faculty

If each Mahavidya develops one irreplaceable human capacity, Bagalamukhi's is best called executive consciousness: the capacity to interrupt any automatic process. To stop a thought. To stop a reaction. To stop speech. To stop fear. To stop desire from hardening into compulsion. To stop inherited conditioning for exactly as long as it takes for freedom to act instead of it.

This is a rarer capacity than it appears, and one with genuine relevance far beyond formal practice, in every domain where a person's life is quietly being run by whatever began moving first. Bagalamukhi does not remove momentum from the world. She restores the student's ability to decide, in each real moment, what continues and what ends.